

1972, SEWA is an organisation of self-employed women, mostly employed in the unorganised labour sector. The body currently has a membership of about seven lakh women, with five lakh in Gujarat alone, spread over 14 districts.

This NGO was recently chosen by India's apex software body NASSCOM as the country's Best IT User 2004, in the NGO category.

Apart from setting up co-operatives and conducting awareness campaigns, SEWA provides supportive services for women—savings and credit schemes, health-care and child-care initiatives, insurance, legal aid, and communication services. It has also developed monsoon- and disaster-proof housing methods, set up fodder-banks. Interestingly, SEWA has developed community-based health centres in a tie-up with WHO and the Gujarat government.

What sets SEWA apart is its innovative use of Information and Communication Technologies (ICTs) to streamline its operations and achieve its goals.

Going Fully Tech

SEWA hit the ICT road with the use of radio, video, mobile phones, fax machines, computers and video-conferencing. These serve as a means of communication and as

I learnt how to e-mail during a workshop conducted by SEWA

Jomiben Jairanbhai of Madhura village, Gujarat

Riyaben Rana Aaiyer uses the mobile phone to replenish supplies for her Bharathaam embroidery



IT User Awards: How SEWA Did IT

According to NASSCOM, the IT User Awards were based on a survey model developed by research firm IMRB to assess an organisation's "e-Readiness or preparedness to adopt ICT infrastructure to boost their business excellence." According to Sangeeta Gupta, Vice President, NASSCOM, "We realised that IT-usage among the NGO community in India was quite low, and decided to find out how many voluntary sector organisations are IT-savvy. Out of the 10 organisations surveyed, SEWA showed how best IT could be leveraged to achieve the 'digital unite', through their innovative use of computers, mobile phones, et al."

an alternate means of employment to the rural poor.

Says Bhatt, "SEWA provides computer-based training to women in local languages. Team leaders are given mobile phones and we use video-conferencing and satellites to communicate with women in other countries."

During emergencies, SEWA uses a satellite talkback communication programme to convey relief and rehabilitation measures to villagers. "SEWA aims to eliminate middlemen and make members self-reliant."

Technology has also helped people avert disasters. She cites the example of a situation in the Kheda district of Gujarat. When heavy rains and floods ravaged the village, the team leaders swiftly contacted the SEWA District Association offices in Anand, Gujarat using mobile phones.

They informed them about the nature of the damage, and eventually sought help from the block administration office. They could also call the District Development Officer and the Collector and asked for medical support and damage assessment teams.

Computers Galore

In trying to increase computer awareness and literacy, SEWA has installed 400 computers across nine districts in Gujarat. Women are given basic training in computer literacy skills, with instructions imparted in the regional language. Community Learning Centres (CLCs) have been set up in several districts to encourage interest in computer-based and general education.

SEWA employs telecommunication and satellite communication devices to conduct educational programmes on themes such as leadership building, forestry, water conservation, health education, child development, and financial services.

The organisation

uses radio broadcasts and video devices to educate people and study community initiatives. Video-conferencing makes it possible for women labourers in rural areas to interact with their counterparts in countries such as Afghanistan, and Pakistan.

The organisation plans to set up information kiosks to communicate government schemes to people at nominal charges. The kiosks will offer surfing and e-mail facilities in rural areas.

They also plan to provide community-specific infotainment content, and create IT-enabled jobs, such data-entry tasks for government agencies and SMEs. SEWA plans to set up region-specific call centres, in collaboration with local private companies.

SEWA is planning tie-ups with some big names, such as Reliance, Tata Consultancy Services and Oracle India to expand the reach of its ICT-enabled initiatives. Oracle India will help SEWA develop a complete database of its members. The idea is to trace their income, health status, education of their children, access to savings and credit, among other things.

SEWA's ICT initiatives are helping women across Gujarat become tech-savvy and self-reliant.

Jasodhaben Bhil, 24, of Vallabh-nagar, Radhanpur taluka, did not study beyond SSC. She uses a laptop with consummate ease to maintain accounts of savings and credit groups in her village.

"Initially, I was very apprehensive about learning to operate computers. But after a ten-day training stint and a little practice, I am able to use the PC fairly well."

Jasodhaben's excitement is apparent—"My husband is illiterate, but he is proud of the fact that I know how to work on a PC!" A shot in the arm for the women's movement in India, courtesy SEWA. ☐

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